political thought only to be questioned or criticized by Indian leaders. At the 2006 *Hindustan Times* Leadership Summit, Nehru's granddaughter-in-law, Sonia Gandhi, spoke on the idea of India as 'The Next Global Superpower' in her capacity as leader of the Congress party, which ruled India at the time. She said that being a superpower 'evokes images of hegemony, of aggression, of power politics, of military might, of division and conflict,' insisting that these images did not reflect India's aspirations.

Sonia Gandhi argued that for centuries 'India exercised a profound influence on the course of world history and it did so without exercising any covert power'. Citing Mahatma Gandhi, Sonia asserted that Indians were able to take on the superpower of the day 'through the mere force of his values and ideas'. She ended her speech by stating: 'We Indians have always known our place in the world even when the world was treating us lightly. … Why should we think of ourselves as a "Global Superpower"? Why not instead work towards becoming a global force for Peace, Progress and Prosperity?'[24] The 2012 policy document *Non-Alignment 2.0* too argued that India was an example to be followed by the world,[25] implying that India could be a moral leader without necessarily having the wherewithal associated with being a great power.

Pursuit of the middle path is not the only legacy of antiquity in contemporary Indian thinking about international relations. Anti-imperialism, which became a key ingredient of India's foreign policy as a legacy of colonial rule and the Indian national movement, is also traced by scholars such as Murty to ancient Indian writings. Murty points out that no ancient Indian writer, whether realist or idealist, 'advocated or contemplated the extension of Indian culture outside of India by force'. [26] In a sense, India's ancient philosophers were isolationists and 'there was a kind of Monroe doctrine towards states outside India' forbidding aggressive wars on states or cultures outside of the Indian subcontinent.[27]